

Mustafa Alperen Ekinci

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Research: Scene processing, empirical aesthetics, visual perception, social perception, individual differences, deep neural networks, eye movements, EEG, fMRI

Education

Ph.D. in Cognitive Neuroscience

Neural Computation Group, Justus-Liebig-University Giessen

Germany
2024-2027

- Supervisor: Prof. Daniel Kaiser
- Topic: "Resolving the Brain Dynamics Underlying Aesthetic Visual Experiences during Movie Watching"

M.Sc. in Neural and Behavioral Sciences

Max-Planck Institutes for Biological Cybernetics - The University of Tübingen

Germany
2021-2023

- Supervisor: Prof. Andreas Bartels
- Thesis: "TrueScenometry: fMRI Responses to True Scene Geometry of Motion in Movies"

B.A. in Psychology

Bogazici University

Turkey
2017-2021

- Supervisor: Prof. Inci Ayhan
- Thesis: "The Effects of Emotions on Time Perception"

Research Positions

University of Toronto - Visiting Scholar

With Prof. Dirk B. Walther and Prof. Oshin Vartanian

Investigated the effects of shared attention and social context on perception.

Canada
Sep - Dec 2026

Max Planck Institute for Biological Cybernetics - Research Assistant

With Dr. Michael Bannert

Investigated fMRI responses to the ground-truth optical flow representation of movies in the brain.

Germany
Oct-Dec 2023

Max Planck Institute for Intelligent Systems - Research Assistant

With Prof. Michael Black

Worked on 4D human motion capture using state-of-the-art motion capture techniques.

Germany
Dec 2021 - July 2023

Michigan State University - Research Assistant

With Prof. J. Devin McAuley

Investigated mechanisms of rhythm synchronization in social context.

USA
Jan - May 2020

Skills

- **Programming:** Matlab, Python, jsPsych
- **Methods:** fMRI, EEG, eye tracker, online experiments
- **Analysis:** Decoding and encoding models of cognitive and perceptual mechanisms, machine learning tools
- **Project management:** Leading independent end-to-end research projects, supervising thesis students

Teaching

- **Teaching Assistant** at JLU Giessen Summer 2025
Neural Computation II - Foundational neural computation methods in cognitive neuroscience II
- **Teaching Assistant** at JLU Giessen Winter 2024
Neural Computation I - Foundational neural computation methods in cognitive neuroscience I
- **Teaching Assistant** at Bogazici University Spring 2021
Introduction to Matlab

Supervision

- **Xueying Yan** Ongoing master's thesis: The role of aesthetic processing in multisensory integration.
- **Mark Merkouchev** Internship: The influence of predictability of an image in visual beauty.
- **Anastasiya Malamud** Internship: fMRI data collection for a multisensory integration experiment.
- **Melis Akdeniz** Master's thesis: The part-whole relationship in art perception.
- **Nina Buhlmann** Bachelor's thesis: Modeling aesthetic experiences across the viewing of an artistic film.

Awards

- **Poster award** at International Association of Empirical Aesthetics (IAEA) 2026
- **Travel award** at International Association of Empirical Aesthetics (IAEA) 2026
- **Young researcher award** from the Scientific and Technological Research Council of Türkiye (TÜBİTAK) 2021

Conferences

- Vision Sciences Society (VSS) 2026
- International Association of Empirical Aesthetics (IAEA) 2026
- European Conference on Visual Perception (ECVP) 2025
- Visual Science of Art Conference (VSAC) 2025

Publications

- [1] **M. A. Ekinci**, N. Buhlmann, and D. Kaiser, "Visual features explain dynamic aesthetic experiences across distinct movie content", *Communications Psychology*, vol. 4, p. 127, 2026.
- [2] **M. A. Ekinci** and D. Kaiser. "Shared gaze reflects shared aesthetic experiences". [Submitted]. bioRxiv: 2026.01.30.702749. [Online]. Available: <https://doi.org/10.64898/2026.01.30.702749>.
- [3] D. Alashan, D. Tanriverdi, **M. A. Ekinci**, and I. Ayhan, "The effects of abutting pattern motion and smooth pursuit eye movement on the visibility of low-contrast luminance-modulated target gratings", *Journal of Vision*, vol. 21, no. 9, pp. 2634-2634, 2021.
- [4] D. Tanriverdi, D. Alashan, **M. A. Ekinci**, and I. Ayhan, "The effect of target motion and smooth pursuit eye movement on the visibility of isoluminant target gratings", *Journal of Vision*, vol. 21, no. 9, pp. 2619-2619, 2021.